

PROGRESS REPORT

Revisiting all the ups and downs over the past one year of India's experiment to reintroduce cheetahs in its wilderness, 70 years after the fastest land animal was hunted to extinction in the country

2022

July: India signs an MoU with Namibia for bringing in African cheetahs

Sept. 17: The first batch of eight cheetahs—five females and three males—arrive at Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh

Oct. 7: A nine-member Cheetah Task Force created to monitor the big cats

Nov. 5-28: All cheetahs moved from quarantine to a larger enclosure stocked with game animals

2023

Feb. 18: Twelve more cheetahs, this time from South Africa, are brought to Kuno

Mar. 11: Two Namibian cheetahs—the couple Oban and Asha—become the first to be released into the wild

Mar. 27: Sasha, a female cheetah, dies of renal complications, marking the first casualty

Mar. 29: Park authorities find four cubs born to Namibian cheetah Siyaya

Apr. 23: Uday, brought from South Africa, dies of cardio pulmonary failure

May 9: Daksha, a female cheetah, dies in "violent mating interaction" with two males

May 18: The Supreme Court raises concern over the deaths, asks the Centre to look into new habitats for the big cat

May 23-25: Three of the four cubs die of dehydration

May 25: The Centre forms a Cheetah Project Steering Committee and a consulting panel of international experts

May 29: Environment and forest minister Bhupender Yadav says no plan to shift cheetahs from Kuno

June 3: Namibian female cheetah Dhatri released into the wild, joining the seven released earlier

The authorities and cheetah experts have been hard-pressed trying to explain that normal mortality rates among cheetahs can be as high as 90 per cent. The adults that died, reasons the government, were already "compromised" when they came to India. MP, meanwhile, has written to the Centre, demanding that a second home be found for the cheetahs as it's becoming tough to manage them at Kuno. The alternative site suggested is the Mukundara park in Rajasthan, but the proposal is finding no takers, either in Jaipur or at the Centre. This, even as the Supreme Court on May 18 raised concern over the deaths, asking the Centre to look into new habitats for the big cat.

"The cheetah deaths have left me sad, but the situation is under control," is what Bhupender Yadav, Union minister of environment, forest and climate change, said on May 29. He was in Bhopal to review the project along with chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan. "I am confident the project will be a success," he added. "As of now, cheetahs will remain in Kuno, and there are no plans to shift them elsewhere."

Per experts, cheetahs usually breed in winters in Africa. In India, however, the cubs faced extreme heat and hence grew weak, leading to mortalities. "More than the breeding cycle," says Cheetah Metapopulation Project manager Vincent van der Merwe, "the issue of prey availability needs to be looked into at Kuno." He is a part of the consulting panel of international experts guiding the 11-member Cheetah Project Steering Committee, constituted soon after the death of the three cubs.

THE INDIAN SUMMER PROVED TOO HARSH FOR THE CUBS AS CHEETAHS USUALLY BREED IN WINTERS IN AFRICA

There are other issues that require attention for the cheetahs to survive in India? Each cheetah being released into the wild from quarantine has two- or three-member teams equipped with communication devices and a vehicle to monitor its movement. The teams work in rotation and the task is extremely challenging. The cheetahs have been travelling substantial distances, and easily exit the reserve as there are no physical barriers to keep them in. If the cheetahs are close to a human habitation and are under any threat themselves or in a position to threaten the livestock, they are tranquilised and brought back.

Scientists have pointed out that in Africa, there is less than one cheetah per 100 sq. km. But the guiding document brought out by MoEFCC states that Kuno, with an area of 750 sq. km, can accommodate around 20-25 cheetahs. That means less than a third of the space available to cheetahs back in Africa. Meanwhile, more cheetahs are being released into the wild. Given the high stakes, the coming weeks will be crucial in determining the success or otherwise of this ambitious project. ■